

**LEARNER CASE · 30 TO 40
MINUTES****MULTIPLE TEAM MEMBERSHIP | LEARNER CASE**

Back from the task force

How can a team leader use someone's outside experience without creating a status contest?

THE DECISION

Sam has ten minutes before the weekly planning meeting. The aim is to use Maya's experience while respecting the knowledge already present in Atlas.

Atlas is the afternoon operations team at a large distribution centre. Its eighteen members receive orders, prepare shipments, answer questions from drivers, and solve delays during a busy shift. Maya has worked in Atlas for four years. Her colleagues trust her, but she has no formal senior role. The team leader and two senior coordinators usually decide how the work is organised.

Six weeks ago, Maya was invited to join Helix, a temporary task force with employees from four locations. Helix had been asked to reduce late departures across the company. Senior managers followed the project closely because delays had become expensive and customers were complaining.

Maya's knowledge of the daily operation proved useful. Other Helix members often asked for her view before making a decision. She led a small test of a new handover method and presented the results at a meeting attended by the operations director. Several parts of Helix's final proposal came from her work. Within Helix, Maya had more influence than she normally has in Atlas.

Maya has now returned to her regular shift. Her job title, pay, and place in the Atlas team have not changed. At the start-of-shift meeting, team leader Sam welcomes her back and says, "It must have been exciting to work on such an important project." Sam then gives Maya her usual tasks.

The first week back

During the next few shifts, Maya regularly mentions Helix. When Atlas has a problem, she explains how the task force handled something similar. Some colleagues want to hear more. Others appear irritated. One colleague says, “Helix could spend all day making plans. We have trucks waiting outside.”

Ruben, one of the senior coordinators, reacts most strongly. He designed Atlas’s current handover sheet and has used it for several years. Maya points out that late order changes are still being missed between shifts. She suggests trying the handover board that Helix tested. Ruben replies that the idea might work elsewhere but does not fit Atlas. The discussion ends without a decision.

The missed changes are a real problem. Earlier that week, the loading team prepared the wrong shipment because a late update had not reached them. Ruben knows the current system well, but he has not found a reliable solution. Maya has seen another method work, although she does not yet know whether it will suit the staffing and layout at Atlas.

Sam wants to make use of Maya’s experience while respecting Ruben’s knowledge of the local operation. Sam also wants to avoid turning the meeting into a debate about whether Maya has become more important than her colleagues.

What should Sam do first?

A	Publicly praise Maya’s work on the important Helix task force and ask her to present everything she learned.
B	Put Maya in charge of replacing the current handover process with the Helix method.
C	Ask Maya and Ruben to choose one Helix idea, adapt it to Atlas, and test it together for one week.
D	Give Maya her normal work and stop discussing Helix so that the team can return to its usual routine.

Map the situation before choosing

RELATIVE STANDING

Relative standing means how much weight a person’s views and contributions carry compared with those of other people in the same team. A person can have high standing in one team and ordinary standing in another.

- Maya’s relative standing in Atlas and Helix.
- How visible and important Helix is within the company.
- What Maya brings back from Helix.
- Which current problem and colleague could benefit from that experience.

Discussion questions

1. How does Maya’s standing differ between Atlas and Helix?
2. Why might her experience in a visible task force affect what happens when she returns?
3. What explains Ruben’s reaction? Give at least two possible explanations.
4. Which option should Sam choose? Explain what it achieves and what risks remain.
5. What should Sam say to Maya and Ruben when giving them the assignment?

6. Design the one-week test. What should Maya provide, what should Ruben provide, and what result should they examine?
7. What information would you need before concluding that Maya's different standing caused her behaviour?

RESEARCH BASIS

This fictional case draws on an observational study of 692 returns by professional football players. Players created more scoring opportunities for club teammates when their relative standing in the club and national teams differed more. The association was stronger when the national team had higher public standing. The same pattern did not appear in the players' own shots or their total recorded activity. These findings do not show that status differences caused the behaviour. The Atlas situation is a teaching adaptation, not an additional study.

Van de Brake, "Returning with a Different Status Position: Status Inconsistency in Multiple Team Membership." Manuscript under review at Organization Science.

https://osf.io/esg7p/?view_only=7e898bf9fec24336b081e5c1e4b5ac10

Learner case developed by Joost van de Brake. h.j.van.de.brake@rug.nl | Supported by the Dutch Research Council (NWO).